

Ritesh Shah felt was tailor made for Bajpayee, who plays a police officer caught up in an accident case where his principles are put to the test. The cast includes Nushrat Bharucha, Divya Dutta, Akshay Oberoi and Kiku Sharda.

Bajpayee was only too happy to return to shoot in Delhi. It is here that he trained with Barry John and began his struggle as a stage actor. "I feel it is a miracle that we survived," he says. "There were days when one didn't know where the next meal would come from and how one would go back to one's room with 50 paise in one's pocket. But we managed."

> The film, feels Bajpayee, focuses on **awakening one's conscience** in times of injustice and churn

Gajab Raat, feels Bajpayee, focuses on awakening one's conscience amidst injustice. "There comes a time when it becomes the driving force," he adds. "It is a time of churning... When rights and wrongs are diluted and merged together, the right has to come out." Bajpayee is glad that Pandey chose to reflect on the society we live in and put it down as a script. The real joy, though, is that he got to work with his friend again. ■

—Suhani Singh

The dialogues also doff a hat to Ram Gopal Varma, whose cult gangster film *Satya* deeply influenced Waikul when he came to Maximum City for his graduation. He decided to become a filmmaker.

He began by assisting and worked with the likes of Ashutosh Gowariker (*Swades*), A.R. Murugadoss (*Ghajini*), Rajkumar Hirani (*3 Idiots*), Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra (*Bhaag Milkha Bhaag*) and Nitesh Tiwari (*Dangal*).

"In India, people think if you have not written the script, you cannot direct," he says. He'd make a showreel and finally get the opportunity to direct in AltBalaji's *The Test Case*, featuring Nimrat Kaur.

After five web series, Waikul is itching to direct a feature, especially as pigeonholing artistes is a favourite pastime of the entertainment industry. "Film is my first love," he says. "In features, the audience is committed. You can be braver with what you want to tell them." ■

—Suhani Singh



MUSIC ▼

Lives Behind the Lyrics

ANAHAD FOUNDATION'S NEW VIDEO SERIES LOOKS BEYOND TRADITION TO EXPLORE THE IMPACT OF INDIA'S FOLK MUSICIANS

Folk music is often celebrated for keeping traditions alive, while the artistes who sing these songs receive less attention. Many practise their art despite limited financial returns, driven by something that goes beyond a livelihood. This is the idea behind *Folktales*, a new social media-forward video series by Anahad Foundation, which has worked with over 10,000 folk musicians across India. Each 90-second film focuses on the person behind the music, their motivations and the place they occupy in their community, rather than the art form itself.

The project builds on Anahad's Backpack Studio, launched in 2016, which took recording equipment to musicians in their villages after founder Abhinav Agrawal found many reluctant to travel to a studio or pay for recordings.

The series includes Bhojpuri singer and storyteller Sukhnandan Yadav, whose retellings of the Ramayana made the epic accessible to audiences unfamiliar with Sanskrit. Another film follows Athira in Kerala, who took up Kanyarkali, an art form traditionally performed by men.

For Agrawal, folk musicians are more than performers carrying forward an inherited tradition. "We want people to realise that folk musicians are not just performers, but creators and carriers of our identity, and no less talented than any urban artiste," he adds. The foundation also plans to expand the series through collaborations, bringing contemporary musicians and creators into villages to work alongside folk artistes and make new music together. ■

—Geetika Sachdev



IN THE ROOTS *Backpack Studio founder Abhinav Agrawal (in white shirt) with musicians and (inset) Kanyarkali artiste Athira*